

The framework that works at big pharma **breaks** at mid-size.

It's almost never the framework. It's what
people carry in with them.

I've worked all three sizes.

15 years in big pharma. Four in mid-size. Then startups. Then back again.

Same regulations every time. Completely different physics.

Small and mid-size companies hire **from** big pharma.

They get the experience they paid for. They also get the mentality that came with it — and nobody mentions that part in the interview.

A PROJECT I WORKED ON

Their first GxP system — and the date mattered.

A statistical computing platform (SAS). Six months, limited scope, roughly 75% out-of-the-box vendor features — with vendor qualification documentation for all of it.

Regulatory submission preparation was waiting on the go-live.

First GxP system. No local precedent.

WHAT HAPPENED

Two months late.

QA asked the CSV team to fully validate the out-of-the-box features — the way you would with a hundred-person validation function and no deadline. The vendor's own evidence sat there, unused.

Submission prep slipped. So did every system downstream.

Risk-based validation: available, unused

The part nobody says out loud:

Over-validation is billable. Under-validation isn't.

That asymmetry shapes more decisions than anyone admits — and the company carrying the delay is never the one being paid for it.

This wasn't a **framework** gap.

Risk-based validation was right there in the SOP. CSA was available. Vendor evidence was leverageable.

But it was their first GxP system — no local precedent, nothing to push back against the imported default: validate everything.

What to unlearn when you move down a size:

- **Validate everything** → proportionate to risk
- **We have a team for that** → you are the team
- **The SOP will tell us** → you will write the SOP
- **Vendor docs aren't enough** → often they're exactly enough
- **A six-week workshop** → a decision, in a room, this afternoon

What actually made me useful wasn't the CSV knowledge.

It was leadership, teaching, negotiation, workshop facilitation, communicating risk to people who don't want to hear it.

The technical part is table stakes. Getting a room of experienced people to change how they work is the job.

Has your org started the AI-in-GxP journey?

Forward this to your QA, CSV or IT lead — especially if your team was built by hiring from bigger companies.

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